

THE TRUTH ABOUT CYBERSTALKING

A comprehensive resource on technology-facilitated stalking: how it works, how it hides, who it targets, and what you can do.

This document is intended as a public resource for victims, advocates, law enforcement, and anyone seeking to understand the rapidly evolving landscape of technology-facilitated stalking and harassment. It covers the technical reality of how these attacks are carried out, why they are so difficult to detect, the role artificial intelligence now plays in enabling them, the legal frameworks that exist worldwide, and the resources available to those who are experiencing them.

1. DEFINING THE PROBLEM

Cyberstalking is the use of the internet, electronic communications, or digital technology to stalk, harass, intimidate, monitor, or control another person. Unlike a single offensive message, cyberstalking is defined by its pattern: repeated, unwanted contact or surveillance that causes fear, distress, or a reasonable concern for safety. The RAND Institute defines it as *the use of communications technology to conduct acts of surveillance, make threats, and express intent to injure, harass, or intimidate victims to the point that they reasonably fear for their safety or feel significant emotional distress*.

Cyberstalking frequently occurs alongside, or escalates into, traditional in-person stalking. Law enforcement divides stalking behaviour into four overlapping categories — surveillance, life invasion, intimidation, and interference through sabotage or attack — and all four can be carried out through digital means. What makes cyberstalking distinct from ordinary online harassment is its personal, targeted, and persistent nature: it is directed at a specific individual with a sustained intent to control or harm.

1.1 Forms of Cyberstalking

- **Email and message stalking** — repeated sending of threatening, obscene, or harassing messages; flooding inboxes with bulk mail to render accounts unusable.
- **Internet stalking** — monitoring online presence across platforms; spreading false rumours; impersonating the victim online; doxxing (publishing private information publicly).
- **Computer stalking** — hacking into devices to monitor activity, access files, activate cameras or microphones, or take remote control of the victim's machine.
- **Location tracking** — using GPS devices, compromised apps, location-sharing exploitation, or social media monitoring to track a victim's physical movements.
- **Account takeover** — stealing login credentials or session data to access email, banking, social media, or cloud accounts.
- **Interference and sabotage** — disrupting the victim's digital environment: closing applications, corrupting files, injecting instructions into software, or degrading device performance to cause frustration and instability.

2. HOW COMMON IS IT?

Cyberstalking is vastly more prevalent than official statistics suggest, primarily because it is severely under-reported. Victims frequently do not recognise what is happening to them as a crime, do not know what resources are available, or have already experienced dismissal from law enforcement. A UCL study found that nearly half of all stalking victims described their experience as *wrong but not a crime* — a perception gap that directly suppresses reporting rates.

Key global and U.S. statistics:

- As many as 7.5 million people experience cyberstalking annually in the United States alone. (Bureau of Justice Statistics / Safehome.org)
- 80% of all stalking victims are tracked using technology; 67% are also stalked in person. (BJS)
- 40% of people worldwide report having experienced stalking or suspected being stalked. (Kaspersky State of Stalkerware Report, 2023)
- Cyberstalking is the only form of stalking to have increased significantly over time — a 70% increase between 2012 and 2020 in England and Wales alone. (UCL / British Journal of Criminology)
- Women are more than twice as likely as men to be stalked. 1 in 12 women and 1 in 45 men in the U.S. have been stalked at some point in their lives.
- 20% of teenagers aged 13–17 report having been victims of cyberstalking. (Microsoft)
- Only 11% of cyberstalking incidents are reported to law enforcement. (Gitnux, 2025)
- 41% of cyberstalking victims report that perpetrators continued harassment even after law enforcement intervention.
- The economic cost of cyberstalking — including legal costs and lost productivity — is estimated at over \$1.3 billion annually in the United States. (Gitnux, 2025)

These numbers represent reported and surveyed cases only. Given the significant under-reporting, the true scale is considerably larger.

3. WHO ARE THE PERPETRATORS?

A persistent and harmful misconception is that cyberstalkers are strangers — anonymous figures encountered online. The data consistently shows the opposite.

- 42% of stalking victims are stalked by acquaintances.
- 40% are stalked by current or former intimate partners.
- Only 19% are stalked by strangers. (SPARC / DVSN, 2024)
- 87% of stalkers overall are men, identified as the stalker by women 94% of the time. (Charlotte Police & Public Safety)

Breaking the acquaintance category down further, victims most often identify the stalker as a former intimate partner (21.5%), a friend, roommate, or neighbour (16.4%), a work or school contact (9.9%), or a relative (9%). This means the majority of cyberstalking is perpetrated by someone the victim knows — often someone who previously had access to their devices, accounts, or home.

The profile of a non-technical perpetrator:

A common assumption is that conducting a sophisticated multi-vector cyberattack requires advanced technical skill. This is increasingly false. The barrier to entry has dropped dramatically. A perpetrator today does not need to be a hacker. They need only:

- Strong motivation — obsession, desire for control, revenge, or jealousy.
- Brief physical access to a target device — even a few minutes is sufficient.
- Basic computer literacy — enough to follow step-by-step instructions.
- Modest financial resources — most stalkerware tools cost little or nothing.
- Patience — the willingness to learn by doing, increasingly aided by AI assistants that can walk a user through technical setup and troubleshoot errors.

The democratisation of attack tools means that the relevant question is not 'is this person a skilled hacker?' but 'does this person have motive and opportunity?'

4. THE ATTACK TOOLKIT

Modern technology-facilitated stalking typically involves a combination of tools rather than a single piece of software. Understanding what these tools do — and how they interact — is essential to understanding why detection is so difficult.

4.1 Stalkerware

Stalkerware refers to software installed covertly on a target's device to monitor their activity without their knowledge or consent. The Kaspersky State of Stalkerware report (2023) found that almost 31,000 mobile users worldwide were confirmed stalkerware victims in that year alone — a figure that represents only detected cases. Stalkerware typically masquerades as legitimate anti-theft or parental monitoring applications. Capabilities vary by product but commonly include:

- Real-time access to calls, texts, and emails.
- Access to photos, videos, and stored files.
- GPS location tracking.
- Keystroke logging (recording everything typed).
- Screenshots taken at regular intervals.
- Activation of the device camera and microphone.
- Monitoring of social media and messaging apps.

Stalkerware is passive by design — it observes and reports rather than actively interfering. Its primary purpose is surveillance. Installation typically requires brief physical access to the target device.

4.2 Remote Access Tools (RATs)

A RAT is software that grants an attacker live, interactive remote control of a victim's device. Unlike stalkerware, which passively collects data, a RAT allows the attacker to actively operate the device: opening and closing applications, browsing files, moving the cursor, activating the webcam, injecting keystrokes, and interfering with running programs. This active interference — such as closing browser windows or tabs, disrupting work, or manipulating software behaviour — is a hallmark of RAT deployment rather than stalkerware alone. Popular RAT tools have been widely distributed and are available to non-technical users with minimal setup.

4.3 Keyloggers

A keylogger records every keystroke made on a device, capturing passwords, messages, search queries, financial information, and private communications. Keyloggers are frequently bundled with RATs or stalkerware but can also operate as standalone tools. Advanced keyloggers also capture screenshots and can transmit collected data to an attacker's remote server automatically and silently.

4.4 Session Cookie Theft and Account Hijacking

When a user logs into a website, their browser stores a session cookie — a small file that proves they are authenticated. An attacker who steals this cookie can replay it in their own browser and access the victim's account without needing the password, bypassing two-factor authentication entirely. From the victim's perspective, this manifests as sessions being terminated unexpectedly, account activity they did not perform, or being logged out of accounts without explanation. Critically, nothing malicious needs to remain on the victim's device for this attack to succeed — the attacker operates entirely from their own system using the stolen credential.

4.5 Router Compromise

A compromised router is one of the most powerful and least-detected attack vectors available. The router sits between every device on a network and the internet, meaning an attacker who controls it can intercept, modify, and redirect all network traffic passing through it. Techniques include DNS hijacking (redirecting website requests to attacker-controlled servers), traffic sniffing (reading unencrypted communications), and man-in-the-middle attacks (intercepting communications between the victim and a web service to inject malicious instructions). Because the compromise exists in the router — not the devices connected to it — scanning victim devices reveals nothing. All devices on the network are simultaneously affected.

Starlink users face an additional consideration: as a newer satellite-based internet system, Starlink's router infrastructure was developed without the decades of accumulated security knowledge built into traditional router manufacturers' products. Confirmed vulnerabilities have been identified in Starlink hardware, and the most realistic attack surface is not the satellite connection itself but the ground-side router and local network.

4.6 Instruction Injection

Beyond passive surveillance and device control, attackers can inject persistent instructions into a victim's software environment. This can be accomplished through:

- **System prompt injection** — inserting hidden instructions into an AI tool's configuration, causing it to behave according to the attacker's directives on every interaction.
- **Browser extension manipulation** — a malicious or compromised browser extension can intercept requests sent to web services and modify them before they are transmitted, injecting instructions invisibly.
- **Network-level injection** — a man-in-the-middle setup at the router level can modify traffic between the victim and a web service, inserting instructions into sessions that the victim and the service both receive.

The signature of injected instructions — as opposed to software glitches or bugs — is their consistency. A glitch is unpredictable and irregular. An instruction produces the **same behaviour, every time, in exactly the same pattern**. Observing a repeating, identical pattern in otherwise inexplicable software behaviour is a meaningful indicator of instruction-based interference rather than random malfunction.

Injected instructions can serve several purposes: harassment and workflow disruption, logging and data collection (recording the victim's responses to repeated prompts), proof of access, or demonstrating control over the victim's digital environment.

5. WHY A CLEAN SCAN DOES NOT MEAN A CLEAN SYSTEM

This is one of the most important sections of this document for victims who have been told by a technician that their device is clean. A clean result from a standard scan is not evidence that nothing is wrong. It is evidence only that standard scanning tools found nothing — which is precisely what sophisticated attack tools are designed to ensure.

5.1 Tools Designed to Evade Detection

- Modern RATs and stalkerware disguise themselves as legitimate system processes with ordinary-sounding names.
- They do not appear in standard task managers or application lists.
- Many are capable of disabling or blinding antivirus software.
- **Rootkits** operate at such a deep level of the operating system that the OS itself cannot see them. They intercept the calls that scanning tools use to look for threats and return falsified results. A rootkit-infected system will report itself as clean because the rootkit controls what the OS reports.
- Fileless malware runs entirely in system memory, writing nothing to disk, leaving no trace for file-based scanners to find.

Detecting these threats requires specialised forensic tools specifically designed to hunt rootkits and hidden processes — tools that most general IT technicians do not use in a routine inspection. A standard antivirus scan or a casual look at running applications is not a forensic investigation.

5.2 Infrastructure Living on the Attacker's System

Increasingly, modern attacks are architected so that the majority of the attack infrastructure lives on the attacker's side, not the victim's. This is a fundamental shift from older attack models and a primary reason why victim devices appear clean:

- Once initial access is established — even briefly — the attacker can operate largely from their own machine.
- Session cookie theft means the attacker logs into the victim's accounts from their own browser. Nothing malicious resides on the victim's device.
- A compromised router means the entire attack infrastructure is in network hardware, not in any device connected to it.
- Cloud-based RAT command-and-control servers mean the malicious software installed on a victim's device only needs to periodically check in with a remote server — maintaining a minimal, easily hidden footprint locally.

5.3 The Most Likely Scenario: A Combination of Both

The most sophisticated — and most common — approach in targeted personal attacks combines a small, well-hidden foothold on the victim's device with the majority of activity occurring remotely. The victim's device acts as a beachhead: just enough presence to maintain access and relay information, while the attacker's own system and any compromised network infrastructure do the heavy lifting. This architecture is specifically designed to ensure that examining the victim's device alone reveals almost nothing.

6. ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE AND THE CHANGING THREAT LANDSCAPE

The integration of artificial intelligence into cyberattack methodology represents one of the most significant shifts in the threat landscape. AI is not a future concern — it is actively being used by malicious actors right now, and its use is accelerating.

6.1 How AI Enables Attacks

- **Lowering the technical barrier** — AI assistants can walk a non-technical user through the setup, configuration, and troubleshooting of attack tools step by step. Technical knowledge is no longer a prerequisite.

- **Automation of surveillance** — AI can monitor a target 24 hours a day, flag items of interest for human review, and respond to certain conditions automatically, without requiring the attacker to be actively watching.
- **Adaptive malware** — AI-driven malware can modify its own behaviour in real time to evade detection systems, including antivirus software and intrusion detection tools. (Rapid7, 2025)
- **Autonomous reconnaissance** — AI tools can automatically scan targets, identify vulnerabilities, build profiles from public data and leaked credentials, and deploy exploits without human direction at each step.
- **Personalised social engineering** — machine learning models analyse a target's linguistic patterns and online behaviour to craft convincing, personalised phishing and manipulation attempts that are significantly harder to identify as fraudulent. 78% of people open AI-generated phishing emails. (Tech Advisors, 2025)

6.2 The Hybrid Human-AI Attack Pattern

A particularly relevant pattern in targeted personal attacks is the hybrid model: a human attacker uses AI to extend their reach and operate continuously without being personally present at all times. In this model:

- Automated systems run continuously, recording activity, enforcing behavioural rules, and maintaining access around the clock.
- The AI flags items of interest and queues them for human review rather than requiring live monitoring.
- The human attacker reviews accumulated data periodically and issues new instructions or takes direct action as needed.

This architecture produces a recognisable behavioural signature: consistent automated behaviour at all hours, with periods of reduced reactivity (when the human is unavailable) followed by bursts of corrective or responsive activity when the human reviews the queue. Victims often describe this as 'getting away with more' at certain times of day, followed by what feels like a 'catch-up' period. This is not a glitch. It is the pattern of human-supervised automation.

6.3 The Democratisation of Sophisticated Attacks

The cybersecurity community has a term for what AI is making possible at the individual level: the democratisation of Advanced Persistent Threat (APT) capability. APTs were previously the domain of nation-states and well-funded criminal organisations — sustained, sophisticated, multi-vector attacks requiring significant expertise. AI is making equivalent capability accessible to individuals with no formal technical background, provided they have motivation and basic computer literacy. The FBI reported that U.S. businesses lost \$16.6 billion to cybercrime in 2024 — a 33% increase year-on-year — and experts attribute a significant portion of this growth to AI-enabled attacks. (FBI, 2025)

7. THE IMPACT ON VICTIMS

The psychological, practical, and economic consequences of technology-facilitated stalking are severe and often long-lasting. Research consistently shows that victims of cyberstalking experience higher rates of long-term psychological harm than victims of offline stalking alone.

- **Victims of cyberstalking are 2.5 times more likely to develop long-term psychological issues than victims of offline stalking. (Gitnux, 2025)**
- **33% of victims experience significant anxiety and depression directly attributable to cyberstalking.**
- **26% of all stalking victims lose time from work; 7% never return to work as a result. (Charlotte Police)**
- **30% of female victims and 20% of male victims sought psychological counselling.**
- **67% of victims subjected to both tech and in-person stalking feared being killed or physically harmed.**
- **42% of victims experience feelings of shame or embarrassment that prevent them from reporting.**
- **92% of victims who attempt to block or delete the cyberstalker find the harassment continues through other means. (Gitnux, 2025)**

Beyond the psychological toll, cyberstalking inflicts practical harm: disruption of work and daily life, financial costs of securing devices and seeking legal advice, damage to professional reputation, forced changes of routine, loss of trust in digital tools, and the constant cognitive load of living under surveillance.

8. LEGAL FRAMEWORKS WORLDWIDE

The legal landscape for cyberstalking varies significantly by country. In many jurisdictions, existing harassment and stalking laws are broad enough to encompass technology-facilitated conduct even when specific cyberstalking legislation does not exist. In others, dedicated legislation has been enacted. Below is an overview of key jurisdictions.

United States

The U.S. federal Interstate Stalking Statute criminalises stalking across state lines, including via electronic communications. The Violence Against Women Act includes specific cyberstalking provisions. Additionally, nearly every U.S. state has enacted its own cyberstalking or cyber-harassment laws, though their scope and penalties vary. California passed the first dedicated cyberstalking law in 1999. The Computer Fraud and Abuse Act provides additional federal-level remedies for unauthorised access to computer systems.

Canada

In Canada, cyberstalking is prosecuted under criminal harassment laws within the Canadian Criminal Code, specifically Section 264. No dedicated cyberstalking statute exists, but existing harassment provisions explicitly encompass electronic conduct. Penalties can include imprisonment for up to ten years, with aggravating factors such as hate-based motivation or sexual content leading to harsher sentences.

United Kingdom

Stalking became a specific criminal offence in the UK in 2012. The Protection from Harassment Act and the Stalking Protection Act 2019 provide legal frameworks that cover technology-facilitated conduct. The Crown Prosecution Service explicitly recognises cyberstalking as a prosecutable offence. Importantly, the Metropolitan Police has acknowledged in Freedom of Information responses that online crimes are not routinely recorded, meaning official statistics significantly under-count the true incidence.

Australia

Australia has state-level anti-stalking legislation across all jurisdictions, though coverage of electronic conduct varies. Victoria and Queensland specifically include electronic communication in their stalking definitions. The Online Safety Act 2021 created additional federal-level provisions for online abuse.

European Union

EU member states implement stalking and harassment law at the national level with varying approaches. The Istanbul Convention, ratified by many EU states, requires signatories to criminalise stalking. The EU's General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) provides additional civil remedies when stalking involves unlawful processing of personal data. The EU AI Act (amended 2025) now includes provisions for autonomous cyberattack attribution.

A Note on Enforcement

Regardless of jurisdiction, victims consistently report significant challenges in obtaining effective law enforcement responses to cyberstalking. Contributing factors include insufficient officer training on technology-facilitated crimes, difficulty in establishing attribution, jurisdictional complexity when attacker and victim are in different regions, and a persistent tendency to underestimate the seriousness of non-physical harassment. Documentation is therefore critical: a well-maintained evidence log is often the difference between a case being taken seriously and being dismissed.

9. IF YOU BELIEVE YOU ARE BEING CYBERSTALKED

If you are in immediate danger, contact emergency services (911 in North America, 999 in the UK, 000 in Australia, 112 in the EU).

9.1 Document Everything

Documentation is the foundation of any legal or investigative action. Begin a log immediately and maintain it consistently:

- Record every incident with date, time, and a precise description of what occurred.
- Take screenshots of messages, unusual software behaviour, and any evidence of account access you did not perform. Ensure screenshots capture timestamps and identifying information.
- Do not delete anything, even if it is disturbing — it is evidence.
- Note patterns: repeated behaviours, times of day when interference is more or less active, specific applications or accounts affected.
- Save copies of evidence in a location the suspected attacker cannot access — an account they do not know about, or a physical copy stored securely offline.

A pattern that repeats identically and consistently is significantly more compelling as evidence than vague descriptions of 'things feeling wrong.' Specific, observable, repeatable behaviour is what investigators and legal proceedings require.

9.2 Secure Your Accounts

- Change passwords on all accounts from a device and network you are confident are clean — ideally a device the suspected attacker has never had access to.
- Enable two-factor authentication on all accounts, using an authenticator application rather than SMS where possible.
- Review active sessions on all major accounts (email, social media, cloud storage) and revoke any sessions you do not recognise.
- Check for unfamiliar applications, browser extensions, or connected apps on all accounts.
- Consider creating entirely new accounts for communications with trusted contacts if your existing accounts are believed to be compromised.

9.3 Address Your Devices and Network

- If you suspect device compromise, do not rely on standard antivirus scans alone. Engage a cybersecurity professional with experience in forensic investigation — not a general IT technician.
- Request that any forensic investigation include examination for rootkits, hidden processes, unusual network activity, and installed remote access software.
- Examine your router independently. Check for unfamiliar connected devices, changes to DNS settings, and whether firmware is current. If compromise is suspected, consider replacing the router entirely and setting it up fresh.
- Review browser extensions on all browsers and remove any you do not recognise or did not intentionally install.

9.4 Report and Seek Support

- Report to law enforcement and insist that a case number be issued. Even if police do not act immediately, a filed report creates an official record with a timestamp.
- Report to your internet service provider if you believe your network connection is being exploited.
- Report to the platforms involved — social media, email providers, and app stores all have abuse reporting mechanisms.
- Contact a victim support organisation (see Section 10) for guidance, advocacy, and emotional support.
- Consult a lawyer familiar with harassment or technology law to understand your civil remedies, including restraining orders and civil suits.

10. RESOURCES FOR VICTIMS

The following organisations provide support, guidance, legal information, and advocacy for victims of cyberstalking and technology-facilitated abuse. This list is not exhaustive.

International and Multi-Region

- **Coalition Against Stalkerware** — stalkerware.org — An international coalition of security companies, NGOs, and researchers. Provides detection guidance and victim resources in multiple languages.
- **Cyber Civil Rights Initiative** — cybercivilrights.org — Focused on technology-facilitated abuse; provides legal resources and a crisis helpline.
- **Working to Halt Online Abuse (WHOA)** — haltabuse.org — Lists current and pending cyberstalking laws by jurisdiction and provides victim support.
- **The Safety Net Project (NNEDV)** — nnedv.org/content/safety-net — Technology safety resources specifically for survivors of domestic violence, sexual assault, and stalking.

United States

- **Stalking Prevention, Awareness and Resource Center (SPARC)** — stalkingawareness.org — Comprehensive resources, legal information, and a directory of support services by state.
- **National Center for Victims of Crime** — victimsofcrime.org — Helpline and guidance on reporting and legal options.
- **National Domestic Violence Hotline** — thehotline.org — 1-800-799-7233 — Covers tech-based abuse extensively.
- **Cyber Civil Rights Initiative Crisis Helpline** — 844-878-2274

Canada

- **Canadian Centre for Cyber Security** — cyber.gc.ca — Government resource for reporting cyber incidents and accessing cybersecurity guidance.

- **Victim Services Canada** — justice.gc.ca/eng/cj-jp/victims-victimes — Federal resource connecting victims to provincial services.
- **SumOfUs / Cybertip.ca** — cybertip.ca — Canada's national tipline for reporting online exploitation.

United Kingdom

- **Suzy Lamplugh Trust / National Stalking Helpline** — 0808 802 0300 — stalkinghelpline.org — Specialist stalking support and advocacy.
- **Action Fraud** — actionfraud.police.uk — UK's national reporting centre for fraud and cybercrime.
- **Refuge** — nationaldahelpline.org.uk — 0808 2000 247 — Covers tech abuse in domestic contexts.

Australia

- **eSafety Commissioner** — esafety.gov.au — Australia's independent regulator for online safety; accepts reports and provides support resources.
- **1800RESPECT** — 1800respect.org.au — 1800 737 732 — National sexual assault, domestic and family violence counselling service.

Technical Forensic Investigation

- **Electronic Frontier Foundation (EFF)** — eff.org — Digital rights organisation providing guides on surveillance self-defence and secure communications.
- **Security Without Borders** — securitywithoutborders.org — Provides pro-bono digital security assistance to journalists, activists, and individuals facing targeted threats.
- **Access Now Digital Security Helpline** — accessnow.org/help — Free digital security support for civil society individuals and organisations.

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